

Consent Form

School of Computing and Information Systems

Technology Innovation Project



Student Researchers: Anita Yang, Tammy Lee, Bella Chen, Leo Lin

Name of Participant:

WINTER YIN

1. I consent to participate in this project, the details of which have been explained to me, and I have been provided with a written plain language statement to keep.
2. I understand that the purpose of this research is to investigate how individuals seek and provide local help within their communities, and to evaluate the potential of a digital platform to improve accessibility, trust, and efficiency in connecting people with local support services.
3. I understand that my participation in this project is for research purposes only.
4. I acknowledge that the possible effects of participating in this research project have been explained to my satisfaction.
5. In this project I will be required to participate in a short interview or survey about my experiences with seeking or offering local help, and I may be asked to provide feedback on a prototype or concept of a digital platform.
6. I understand that my interviews may be audio recorded.
7. I understand that my participation is voluntary and that I am free to withdraw from this project anytime without explanation or prejudice and to withdraw any unprocessed data that I have provided.
8. I have been informed that the confidentiality of the information I provide will be safeguarded subject to any legal requirements; my data will be password protected and accessible only by the named researchers.
9. I understand that given the small number of participants involved in the study, it may not be possible to guarantee my anonymity.
10. I understand that after I sign and return this consent form, it will be retained by the student researchers.

Participant Signature:

A handwritten signature in blue ink, appearing to be 'WINTER YIN', written over a horizontal line.

Date:

31/03/2026

HelpMate

Semi-Structured Interview Guide

INFO90010 Technology Innovation Project | Group B

How to use this guide

Q Core question Ask every interviewee. Do not skip.

↳ Probe / follow-up Use when the interviewee touches on that theme. Not compulsory.

↘ Conditional branch Only ask if a specific situation or keyword is mentioned.

💡 Interviewer tip Reminders on technique — not read aloud.

Interviewee:	Daniel Yin	Date:	31/03/2026
Interviewer:	Yang-Chun Lin	Location:	Iglu Melbourne Central

Opening Script (read aloud)

"Hi, thank you for meeting with us. We are postgraduate students from the University of Melbourne working on HelpMate — a hyper-local platform that helps people exchange small everyday tasks and resources with others nearby. Before we start, please read the Plain Language Statement. Any questions? [Pause] Great. May I also record our conversation for note-taking purposes? [Wait for consent signature.] Let's begin."

Section 1 — Background (3–4 min)

Q1

Can you tell me a bit about yourself — what you are studying or doing, how long you have lived in your current area, and what your living situation is like (relationship between you and your neighbors)?

Response notes:

Master of Marketing Communication

Living at a student accommodation for about one year – Scape

There is a lot of chances to meet with neighbors through dining time offered by the accommodation. They offer 3 meals per day, so that people would hang out quite often during that time.

Q2

How well do you know your neighbours or the people around you?

↳ If they say they barely know them:

"Has there ever been a moment where you wished you knew them a bit better? What was the situation?"

⚡ *If they say they know neighbours well:*

"How did that come about — was there a particular moment or event that helped you connect?"

He doesn't know many people living within that building. He usually eats alone during dining time.

He says he wanted to know more people because one of his goals of studying in Melbourne is improving his English by communicating with your neighbours. He's a bit introverted. He cannot say that he would be really close with his neighbours due to his personality

Section 2 — Current Behaviours (5–7 min)

💡 **Interviewer tip:** *Ground questions in real past events, not hypotheticals. If they start speaking generally, redirect: "Can you walk me through a specific time that happened?"*

Q3

Think about the last time you needed help with something small — like borrowing a tool, getting a ride, or carrying something heavy. What did you do, and why did you choose that approach?

↳ *Consequence probe:*

"And how did that turn out? Did it solve the problem, or did it leave you feeling frustrated?"

↳ *If they ended up buying something they only needed once:*

"Looking back, do you feel like that was the best solution? What would have been ideal?"

⚡ *If they mention feeling awkward or hesitant to ask:*

"That's totally ok — can you tell me a bit more about why it felt uncomfortable? Was it about the person, or more of a general feeling?"

Response notes:

He does most of the things by himself because he doesn't really like to bother other people. If he can use money to solve his problem, he will just spend the money he thinks it's necessary. Or just ask his close friends.

He agrees that this kind of shopping is a waster, but it's still better to not bothering someone he doesn't know that well.

Q4

Have you ever been in a situation where you needed help but genuinely did not know who to turn to, or felt too uncomfortable to ask? Can you walk me through that?

↳ *Emotional probe:*

"How did that make you feel at the time? Did you manage to resolve it eventually?"

↳ Frequency probe:

"Does that kind of situation come up often for you, or was it more of a one-off?"

↪ If they mention being new to the area or being an international student:

"It sounds like the lack of a local network made this harder. Is that something you would say affects you regularly?"

Response notes:

He got a fleg around 5 months ago, and he was scared to infect someone else.

He does feel a bit uncomfortable asking for help under normal context.

Q5

Have you ever helped someone nearby — a neighbour, classmate, or even a stranger? What was that like, and what motivated you to help?

↳ Extending probe:

"Would you do it again? Is there anything that would make you more or less likely to help someone in a similar situation?"

↪ If they say they have never helped anyone nearby:

"Has there been a moment where you considered helping but decided not to? What held you back?"

Response notes:

He helped a female stranger carrying heavy boxes while she was trying going upstairs. And he wanted to help her for no reason, he's just a warm person.

Section 3 — Challenges & Pain Points (4–5 min)

Q6

When you try to find help — through apps, social media, or friends — what is the most frustrating part of that process?

↳ If they mention slow or unreliable responses:

"How long would you be willing to wait before you gave up and tried something else?"

↳ If they mention trust or safety concerns:

"Can you describe what a trustworthy source of help would look like to you?"

↪ If they say they do not use any apps or platforms for this:

"That's really useful to know — what is your go-to approach then? And has it ever let you down?"

Response notes:

Most of the close friends are not in the same country as him, so that they cannot help him immediately.

Q7

Have you ever used a platform like Facebook groups, WhatsApp groups, or Nextdoor to ask for or offer help? What worked, and what did not?

↳ If they had a bad experience:

"What specifically went wrong? Was it something about the platform itself, or the people involved?"

↪ If they say they have never tried any platform:

"What has stopped you from trying? Is it more about awareness, trust, or something else?"

Response notes:

Asking people for physical help via applications online is risky to him.

He used Facebook marketplace to sell and buy things before. He thinks the success of process is not about the platform itself. It's about human interaction

Section 4 — Reaction to the Platform Idea (5 min)

💡 Interviewer tip: Read this brief platform description aloud before Q8: "Our platform lets you post small help requests on a map — like borrowing a tool or asking for help moving boxes — and people nearby can respond. There is also a reputation and reward system to build trust between users."

Q8

What is your first reaction to this idea? Can you imagine a situation in your own life where you would actually use something like this?

↳ If they give a positive reaction:

"What is the thing that appeals to you most about it?"

↳ If they seem sceptical or lukewarm:

"That's fair — what would need to change about it for it to feel genuinely useful or appealing to you?"

↪ If they immediately describe a specific use case:

"That is a great example. Walk me through what that interaction would look like — what would you post, and what would you hope to happen next?"

Response notes:

It's quite innovated because he has never seen this kind of service before.

If he really needs something specific but doesn't want waste his money. He will try it because knowing other users are doing similar things on this platform makes him feel safer.

Q9

What would make you hesitant to use this platform, or stop using it after trying it once?

↳ Solution probe:

"What would need to be true for those concerns to go away?"

↗ If they raise safety or stranger-danger concerns:

"What features or signals would make you feel safe enough to interact with someone you had never met before?"

↗ If they mention not having time or motivation:

"How much effort would you be willing to put into something like this — say, on a scale from checking it daily to only posting when you're desperate?"

Response notes:

Reaching out to a stranger online is a bit scary. Especially we currently do not offer any type of insurance.

He gives an example that someone tries to borrow one thing from another person, since our team won't have an inspector going to the place where they meetup, the lender can probably express that he wants to charge before he lends his stuff. This scenario might be a concern.

Some background investigation on users should be done upon registration

Section 5 — Trust, Safety & Incentives (4–5 min)

Q10

What would make you trust someone enough to accept help from them, or offer to help them, through this platform?

↳ If they mention a rating or profile system:

"How many reviews or interactions do you think someone would need before you felt comfortable trusting them?"

↗ If they are sceptical that any online signal could build enough trust:

"Is there anything in real life — outside of an app — that gives you that kind of trust in a stranger? Could something like that be replicated digitally?"

Response notes:

He wants to see other users' review and comments because rating itself is a bit not enough.

Q11

If there were a points or reputation system where you earned recognition for helping — would that motivate you, or would it feel artificial? Why?

↳ If they say it would motivate them:

"What kind of reward or recognition would feel meaningful to you — badges, a visible score, real-world benefits, or something else?"

↪ *If they find it artificial or off-putting:*

"So what would motivate you to help someone you don't already know? Is there anything that could make it feel natural rather than transactional?"

Response notes:

He thinks that's a good feature to have to motivate people to help others. And through this system, it can somehow prove that he's a nice person if he gets enough credit

He thinks ranking system makes the process more fun and more visible to people (quantify your kindness)

Section 6 — Feature Priorities (2–3 min)

Q12

If this platform launched tomorrow with only two or three features, what would be the most important ones to you, and why?

↪ *If they suggest a feature you had not considered:*

"That is interesting — can you tell me more about why that matters to you specifically?"

↪ *Anything else probe:*

"Is there anything else — maybe something you have seen in a completely different app — that you think could work really well here?"

Response notes:

1. Insurance or safety check
2. Even some more fun features (like a video when you're helping others – like IG reels)

Closing Script (read aloud)

"Is there anything else about this kind of platform — or your own experiences getting or giving help — that you think we should know? [Pause] Thank you so much for your time. Your responses will be kept confidential and referred to by a pseudonym in any reporting. You are welcome to withdraw at any time."

Additional Observations

Use this space for body language, emotional cues, unexpected themes, or follow-up items for analysis: